

Berkeley and Russell on Idealism: Do Material Objects Really Exist?

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In early modern philosophy, empiricists such as Locke, Berkeley, and Hume have attempted to elucidate the concept of substance. Intuitively to most, there exists an external world outside of our senses. The world we perceive around us through sight, smell, hearing, taste and touch seems to exist regardless of whether we were to be a part of it or not, and few people would say otherwise. Despite this, Berkeley's famous concept of idealism challenges all of these notions. With the help of objections by Bertrand Russell in his book *Problems of Philosophy*, I argue that natural law provides a more coherent and grounded explanation for perception and object interaction than Berkeley's idealism, thereby undermining the possibility of immaterialism.

Berkeley's term idealism encapsulates his main argument that there exist no external matter or material objects, only ideas within the mind that we form through sensory experience. Berkeley claims that we perceive only sensations, not the underlying substance that makes up external objects. In order to back up this extraordinary claim, he relies on a few arguments. First, he attempts to discount the validity of both primary and secondary qualities, a distinction made by Locke to describe the characteristics of substances. Berkeley claims that all qualities, both primary and secondary, are mind-dependent, and therefore immaterial. The example of heat, used by Berkeley in the First Dialogue, follows as such: if an object has the quality of heat or being hot, we perceive that quality through feeling pain upon touching it. Because pain is a mental state, heat is therefore a mind-dependent and immaterial quality. Without a mind to perceive it, heat would be a meaningless idea according to Berkeley. Locke uses the qualities of shape and

size as prime examples of primary qualities. However, Berkeley says otherwise. The size of an object as we perceive it depends on our distance from said object, and is therefore dependent on the viewer. If we were to try to measure the size of an object with a ruler for example, the measurement would change depending on how close or far we are away from the object. The shape of an object similarly changes relative to our vantage point, and must be subjective.

In the dialogue between Hylas and Philonous that Berkeley uses to illustrate his points, Philonous the idealist challenges Hylas to describe matter. He fails to do so without describing the qualities ascertained only through the senses. Philonous argues that if matter is only known by the senses, it is mind-dependent and therefore not objectively material. If one tries to argue that matter has no perceivable qualities, the idea is meaningless and incoherent. We have no reason to believe in something we can neither sense nor describe, doing so would be contradictory to the strict empiricism held by Berkeley and others. Assuming the existence of something we know nothing about, according to Philonous (and subsequently Berkeley) is contrary to common sense. In order to describe how objects interact without human perception, Berkeley claims that God, in His infinite power, perceives everything all at once. This way, nothing ever goes unperceived, thus leaving objects free to interact without objection. Depending on this claim, Berkeley avoids an obvious pitfall of his argument. But is it really as strong as he hopes?

Russell's refutation of Berkeley focuses on arguing that matter and material objects do exist, and that we have reasons to justify believing so. Russell uses multiple examples to argue his thesis. Firstly, he makes the distinction between sense-data and physical objects. Sense-data is what our perception consists of—what we see, touch, smell, taste, and hear. No one will doubt that sense-data creates an idea of an object in our head, and that that idea is unique to us. If many

people perceive the same object, they may do so slightly differently depending on their vantage point, difference in sensory organs, etc. but they will agree and form a common consensus about the object. This is because difference in perception can be accurately predicted by natural law. A calculation of angles, reflections, and shadows, although not practically reasonable, would account for the variance used by Berkeley to refute the existence of primary qualities.

Russell gives the example of a hungry cat. If we perceive a cat at t_1 and at t_2 , the cat being hungry at t_2 and not t_1 , we have reason to believe that the cat exists regardless of our perception. The cat's hunger is not immediately perceptible by our senses, but it still exists as a mind-independent condition of the cat's existence. Russell's argument culminates in his claim about the lack of exclusivity between ideas of objects and their real existence. Building off of the premise that sense-data undoubtedly creates the idea of an object in our mind, he claims that that fact does not rule out the possibility that an external object doesn't ALSO exist. We have no reason to believe in Berkeley's claim, especially because the existence of objects is clear and intuitive. It simplifies our view and explanation of the world, and thus should not be doubted without equally clear evidence, which Berkeley fails to produce.

Berkeley's attempted dissolution of primary and secondary qualities is strongly refuted by Russell's introduction of natural laws into the equation. Taking that logic one step further, a defense against idealism can be created. Berkeley's position on natural laws involves using God's universal perception as a way to defend his immaterialism, stating that God observes everything all at once, allowing for interaction between objects even if a human is not participating. Relying on Russell's example of a hungry cat, we see this assumption challenged. If we suppose that God's perception follows similar natural laws—a point Berkeley fails to establish—then God's perception would be subject to the same limitations as ours, and thus

insufficient to account for all object interactions. For instance: if God perceives through visual-like means and obeys the natural laws that govern that perception, he would be unable to see through solid objects. We see that His perception then, cannot account for unseen internal changes like in the hungry cat example.

Despite this discrepancy, we see consistency in these changes, suggesting that they occur regardless of perception. Imagine the following: a weight is attached to a rope ready to swing towards a glass vase at the sound of an alarm. This apparatus is contained within a locked box, and the viewer will be unable to perceive anything happening inside. After the allotted time for the alarm to sound, without opening the box, we can be sure that the apparatus functioned and that the glass vase is now shattered. If we were to open the box, our hypothesis would be confirmed. Now, whether or not I observe that the glass is broken, understanding natural law leads me to the correct conclusion about the state of the vase. Through this experiment, we see that natural laws operate outside of our perception. If natural laws operate outside of our perception and the interaction between objects is governed by natural law, we can come to the conclusion that the interaction between objects operates outside of our perception. If this is true, Berkeley's idealism is false, and there exists a material world external to us and our perception. This position reflects Russell's preference for simplicity in explanation. Testable, reliable natural law needs no theological dependence, and thus contains one less assumption.

Berkeley, in his stubbornness, would undoubtedly raise a few challenges to this argument. Berkeley would likely appeal to the nature of God's perception used as a premise to my argument, stating something along the lines of God not needing anything similar to sight, knowing all things directly and immediately. Changes imperceptible to us would still be perceptible to God if this were true. This argument, while possibly true, offers no real refute to

my reliance on natural law and not God's perception, as a predictor for object interaction.

Berkeley would fail to back up this claim about God's perception as there is no evidence for its truth. Natural law is a much more reliable explanatory framework for perception than an unknowable and indiscernible proposition such as that of infinite and unbounded perception.

By using the vase-in-a-box thought experiment, it could be argued that I am begging the question: assuming that objects interact independently of our perception in order to prove that very point. This is not the case. I am not making any assumption about the fact that objects interact with each other, but rather employing the regularity of natural laws as a means to predict so. Inferring based on past experience that natural laws would govern the interaction is the very point of natural law, which Berkeley himself would admit to be true.

A defender of idealism might offer one last objection—that regularity and consistency do not require mind-independent reality, only that God is the cause behind us perceiving such predictability. On this view, a cat being hungry and a vase shattering would be explainable as part of a divinely regulated system. This response however only restates the problem: it depends on theological assumption rather than offering a robust framework to explain the regularity. It would be in our best interest to appeal to the type of natural law offered by Russell in order to explain how objects interact, which is a much more empirically grounded explanation than Berkeley's assumption about God.

Berkeley's idealism, while abstract and hard to believe, is equally difficult to refute. However, Berkeley's reliance on theological assumption becomes the weakness of the system. As we seek to construct a refutation, Russell's examples of the hungry cat and my proposed thought experiment of the vase in a box demonstrate that the natural laws that govern perception and mind-independent object interaction refute Berkeley's arguments for idealism. Dependence

on natural law offers a much more reasonable explanation to mind-independent object interaction, and better aligns with our lived experience in the world.